

What I Wish I Knew

A Field Guide for New ServSafe Proctors & Instructors

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Zero to Paid — Proctor Toolkit

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Foreword

The second time I had to get my ServSafe Manager certification I ended up in a class taught by someone from an HR department who didn't know the material. They read from the book. When students asked questions they shrugged them off. I looked around the room and could see it on people's faces — they were going to fail before we even picked up a pencil.

I thought — if this person can be a proctor, what could I do better?

So I looked into it. Figured it wasn't as hard as I thought. Became a proctor.

My first client was a day care center. Two employees who needed to get certified. I stumbled my way through it. Embarrassing, honestly. But I got through it and I learned.

ServSafe wasn't much help. They gave you the credential and static information you already knew. What I needed to know was practical — who to contact, how to run a class, what to do when a student isn't getting it, how to handle the room. They expected me to figure that out on my own.

So I did. Through success and failure. Over 3 years.

There were times I thought this was way more difficult than I anticipated. But the money was becoming significant — so I stuck with it. Eventually it became a career.

What I'm giving you today is what took me 3 years to learn. Nobody gave it to me. I'm giving it to you.

FoodSafetyMadeEasy.com has one purpose — to support you. That's it. There has never been a resource for you. At least not one that knows you. That understands the entrepreneurial step you're taking. That offers real world advice.

Your journey is our journey. Your success is our fuel. Share your questions in our blog. Make recommendations. You're not in this alone.

Until now — you were in this alone.

— Gerry Miller, Novern Management
FoodSafetyMadeEasy.com

Chapter 1 — What This Business Actually Is

Bottom line — this business is about people. People who have a specific need that you help them attain. Interaction is your key to success.

Actually caring and pretending to care are easily noticed. If you're going to do this, make sure you actually care about what you're doing. If not, this isn't for you.

You serve a need. A desperate need at times. You have to understand the client. These people aren't coming to you because they want to be certified. They're coming to you because they have to be.

This is about people — not certification. Every walk of life is going to sit in front of you. You have to adapt.

That being said, this is a simple business. It's work. Lots of work. In the beginning you will dedicate more time than you have. That's the reality.

But the beauty of it is this — once you establish yourself, you make good money. You have the satisfaction of knowing you solved a need. And hopefully you made not just a business acquaintance, but somebody who trusts you, who will recommend you, and who knows — may actually become a friend.

Chapter 2 — Getting Started Without Overthinking It

This is a simple business. But there are things you're going to need.

Obviously you need to be certified. We already covered that. Next comes equipment — and it isn't much. It can get elaborate if you want it to be, but at the core you need a laptop, some form of curriculum, posters, and a syllabus. That's it to start.

For the business-minded person there are ways to capitalize on the necessities your students need anyway. Exam vouchers are a good example — you can purchase them through ServSafe and charge students a few dollars more than what you paid, or bundle them into your packages. It's a small margin but it adds up over time and it simplifies the process for the client. They come to you for everything. That's the goal.

You'll also want a way to collect payment before the session. Square and Stripe both work well. Set it up before your first client — not after.

Here's the real beauty of this business — if you charge somebody fifty dollars just to proctor? That's all profit. No overhead. No inventory. No cost of goods. You show up, you administer the exam, you leave with fifty dollars you didn't have before. Scale that across ten students in a group session and you've had a very good afternoon.

Most importantly, understand that this is not an overnight success story. Nobody enters this business with a client list ready to go. You have to find these people. Cold calling works. A simple website works. Word of mouth — once you get going — works better than anything.

Whatever path you take, mindset is the most important thing. It takes time. The proctors who quit do so in the first 90 days, usually after one or two awkward sessions, before the referrals start coming in. The ones who stick it out past that point almost always find their footing.

Give it time. The clients are out there. There are 600 licensed food establishments in Madison County alone — and that's one county.

Chapter 3 — Your First Client

That first client. Like your first true love — you will never forget them.

You had to work at it. You had to resource it. You maybe even had to sell yourself. How you found that person — that's your story. Mine was through cold calling. That was almost twenty years ago and I still remember that session. However awkward it was, getting through it showed me that this could be profitable. This could be rewarding.

Nobody is going to ring your doorbell and say "I need to get certified." That's not how this works. For every ten people you cold call, maybe one will be a lead. That lead may turn into something, or it may not. But like a pyramid these things grow over time.

I stopped doing this full time five years ago. I still have people calling me asking me to certify them. That's the pyramid effect. You build it slowly, and then it builds itself.

I gave you a cold call script in this package. That script has been with me a long time. You can reword it, make it your own — but the essential is there. Remember who you're dealing with. These people need to be certified. They don't want to go through the process, but they have to. You are a necessary component.

You're not the only proctor out there. So make a great first impression. Be professional. Be reliable. Show up on time. Answer your phone. Those four things alone will put you ahead of most of your competition.

At some point I hope you ask yourself — because you were either in a class, studied on your own, or were proctored — how did that person do? Were they respectful? Were they knowledgeable? Did they present themselves professionally? Or did they lack in some areas?

My guess is the latter.

The people who are successful at this understand it is about people. And the people you're dealing with are probably not overly excited about the prospect of being there. You differentiate yourself by how you treat them.

Chapter 4 — The Clients Nobody Talks About

There is a whole world of clients out there that nobody is calling. And they are not hard to find once you know where to look.

Here is the list most proctors ignore — and why each one matters:

Hospitals

Large staff, high turnover, and a dietary department that is required to maintain certification at all times. One contact in a hospital can mean recurring business for years.

Schools

Every school district has a food service department. One director oversees multiple buildings. One call can get you five to ten students in a single session.

Prisons and correctional facilities

Nobody thinks to call them. They have full kitchens, rotating staff, and a constant certification need. They are also institutional — meaning once you are their proctor, you stay their proctor.

Day care centers

State licensed, required to have certified staff, and the director is usually handling everything including compliance. Easy first call. Easy yes.

Assisted living and nursing homes

Same logic as hospitals. Dietary staff turns over constantly. The need never goes away.

Grocery stores

The deli counter, the bakery, the prepared foods section — all of it requires certified managers. Independent and regional grocers are wide open.

Bowling alleys, golf courses, country clubs

Food service is secondary to their main business which means certification often falls through the cracks. These are easy calls because they are rarely being called by anyone else.

Corporate cafeterias and manufacturing plants

Companies with on-site dining need certified managers just like any restaurant. High employee count, regular turnover, and a facilities or HR manager who just wants the problem solved.

None of these people are advertising that they need a proctor. That is exactly why you call them.

Develop the observation habit. Everywhere you go — a restaurant, a deli counter, a food truck, a catering event — look for the ServSafe certificate on the wall. If you don't see one, that's a lead. If you see only one and the place has ten employees, that's a lead. Train yourself to notice. It becomes automatic.

And when you see it — ask the question. One question: "Do you have anyone who needs to get their ServSafe certification?" That's it. You're not selling. You're asking. Most of the time the answer is yes or not right now. Not right now is still a lead — follow up in three months.

I'll give you two stories that illustrate this better than any advice I could offer.

I was at a local Mexican restaurant I had been going to for years. I noticed only one ServSafe certificate on the wall. I asked Juan about it. His daughter needed to get certified but they just didn't have time. Since this was one of my favorite places to eat we worked out a barter — I certified her, class and proctoring, for ten free meals for me and my wife. No money changed hands. But that's not the point. The point is I was sitting there anyway. I just asked the question.

The second story came from Luke Air Force Base in Arizona. If you've never been inside a military base it's like a small city. One afternoon me and the food court manager grabbed lunch from one of the trucks on base. The operator had three trucks run by his family. I asked the question — did he have ServSafe certificates for his staff?

No. He knew he needed them. His whole family was part of the business and none of them were certified.

That afternoon I booked three clients for a classroom session. A hundred and twenty five dollars each. They purchased their own exam vouchers. My cost — zero.

You are going to be in places every single day where potential clients are working. Pay attention. Ask the question. The worst they can say is no.

Chapter 5 — Pricing — What to Charge and Why Cheap Is a Mistake

The impulse when you start is to find out what everyone else is charging and charge less. Let me tell you why that is a mistake.

The people you are calling are not shopping for the cheapest option. They are looking for someone who can get this done — today or tomorrow. They have a compliance need and they want it resolved. Price is rarely the deciding factor. Reliability and availability are.

Set your pricing to be fair. There is no need to undercut.

When I was doing this full time in the Midwest, the going rate for proctoring was around sixty five dollars. I charged ninety to a hundred and twenty five dollars depending on the package — the refresher or the in-depth class. That pricing worked because it reflected the value of what I was providing, not a race to the bottom.

You will need to research your own market. The East Coast will bear more than the Midwest. Seattle is going to be more than Billings. Spend an hour finding out what others in your area are charging and set your price around that. You don't need to be the cheapest. You need to be available, professional, and easy to work with.

Here is the math that matters. Fifty dollars for an hour's work with one person — that's decent money. Two hundred dollars for four people in the same hour — that's great money. It's not just about what you charge. It's about building volume. One client becomes two. Two becomes five. Five becomes a referral network.

One thing I figured out over time — perceived extras matter. People don't want to buy the exam voucher separately. If you include it in your package price and present it as part of the package, that's perceived value. They feel like they're getting more. You're simplifying the process for them and charging accordingly. Everyone wins.

But here is the real thing you need to understand. Figuring out what to charge is the easy part. The hard part is managing your time. Time is your most expensive resource. The drive to the location. The setup. And most annoyingly — unprepared students who extend the session far beyond what it should have been.

Getting students prepared to pass — that is your mission. I've had very few students fail and I take each one personally. What I learned over time is that students who come in unprepared cost you time, and time is money. Do whatever you need to do to get them ready before they walk in the door.

This is exactly why the [SafePrep](#) app was created.

Chapter 6 — The Renewal Pipeline — Why This Business Compounds Over Time

This may be my favorite thing to talk about.

Every five years the people you certify need to get certified again. While they may not remember your name specifically, they remember the process — and more importantly, they remember whether you made it easy. Send an email or make a call when renewal time is approaching and ninety percent of the time they will use you again. Not because they went looking. Because you showed up at the right moment and they already trusted you.

That is the pyramid. Every client you certify today is a potential client five years from now. And if they referred someone in between — which they will if you earned it — that person becomes a renewal client too. The business compounds quietly in the background while you're working on the next one.

I cannot stress enough how much word of mouth means in this business. Think of yourself as a walking Yelp review. Did you earn five stars or did you just go through the motions? Being a five star experience is what gets you talked about.

To this day I'm still amazed at how an industry with millions of people in it generates almost no conversation about getting certified. Why would it? To most people it's just an annoyance — something they have to do, not something they choose. But that's exactly why word of mouth is so powerful here. When someone has a good experience they remember it because the bar is so low.

I still get calls from people saying — so and so told me about you, can you do this tomorrow? Those calls happen organically. You don't buy them. You earn them.

Get a website. It does not have to be fancy. It does not have to accept payments or schedule appointments. It just needs to say who you are, what you do, and where you operate. I have an old Wix site that has been essentially shut down for years. It still gets visitors. People searching for ServSafe certification in my state, my county, my city — they find it. If I started up again today that site would get me five to ten qualified contacts a month. And it was the most basic site I ever built.

Create a Facebook page for your business. Instagram too. You don't need to post every day or build a following. Just have a presence. Put your name, your service area, and a way to contact you. Set up a Google Business Profile — it's free and puts you on the map literally. When someone searches "ServSafe proctor near me" a Google Business listing is often the first thing they find.

Set these up once. Keep them current. Let them work for you while you're doing everything else.

Chapter 7 — Cold Calling Without Hating It

This is the elephant in the room.

You either hate calling or you despise calling. I can't think of anybody who wakes up in the morning and says — yes, I get to make cold calls today. With that being said, there is an art form to this. And like most art forms, it gets easier with practice.

Keep in mind what this business is. It is not a certification business. It is a people business. How you present yourself on that call is everything. You have approximately thirty seconds before someone decides whether they are going to listen to you or get rid of you. Make those thirty seconds count.

A cold call in this business is about facts, but more importantly it is about benefits. Not what you do — what you can do for them. Here is what I can do for you. Let me make this easy. I can come to you. Those are the phrases you want leading every call.

I have never approached cold calling as a salesman. I approach it as someone who can be of help. Here is what I can do for you. What do you need? I can do that. That is the entire framework in three sentences. You are not pitching. You are solving.

In this business a cold call goes one of two ways. Either — no, we're good, click. Or — yes, what do I need to do? I have three employees and I have no idea how to handle this. The moment you get that second response you are ninety percent of the way to getting paid. All you have to do from that point is make it easy for them. Answer their questions. Give them a price. Pick a date. Done.

How to handle the most common objections:

"We already have someone." — Completely fine. May I ask when your next renewal is coming up? Note the date. Call back two months before. That proctor may not be available. You will be.

"We're not due for a while." — Same answer. When is your renewal? Note it. Call back. People forget. You won't.

"We handle that through corporate." — Thank them and move on. Corporate accounts are harder to crack and not worth the time when you're starting out.

"How much does it cost?" — Have your answer ready before you call. Don't hesitate. Hesitation signals uncertainty and uncertainty loses sales.

No answer. — Leave a short voicemail. Your name, what you do, your number. Fifteen seconds maximum. Call back once more in a week. After that move on.

Cold calling to me was always a time filler. No clients today. No follow-ups needed. Three hour gap in my schedule. Let me make some calls. It was never the centerpiece of my day — it was what filled the space between everything else.

I give you lists in this package. I never had those. I had to find every name myself — researching businesses, tracking down contact names, building a database from nothing. You're welcome.

Approach it however you want to, but understand this — cold calling is what makes your business grow. It is what will sustain it. It is what builds the foundation. And it is what will get you referred.

Quite often you will get — I don't need to get certified, but the guy down the road does. Organic things happen when you make phone calls. Not every time. Not even most of the time. But every now and then something unexpected comes from a call you almost didn't make.

That is how the pyramid grows.

Here is the best part — these calls are not a one and done. Call every three to four months. Turnover happens. The person who told you they were all set six months ago may have two new managers who need to get certified today. The guy down the road may have finally gotten around to it. Stay on the list. Stay consistent. The business compounds because you keep showing up.

Make the calls.

Chapter 8 — What I Wish I Knew on Day One

How do you end a story like this?

What I wish I knew on day one is a never ending list. That is exactly why this website came into existence. That is exactly why I built the SafePrep app. Everything in this guide — every lesson, every story, every piece of advice — I wish someone had handed to me on day one.

If I had this information when I started, my business wouldn't have taken two years to become profitable. Within six months I would have been making good money. Real money. Not because I'm exceptional — but because I was willing to put in the work. I understood the value of time. I was willing to do what needed to be done. The only thing missing was the roadmap. That's what you're holding right now.

Two things came into my life this past year that I'm genuinely proud of.

The first is the SafePrep app. I built it because of every person who ever tried to train me in a classroom, and every instructor I watched present a class over the years. None of them delivered the way they should have. None of them truly understood who they were working with or how those people learned. I wanted to build something different — an app that the everyday person could relate to, that understood how they learned and adapted to them accordingly. I think SafePrep is almost revolutionary in the way it teaches. I'm proud of that.

The second is this website. It is long overdue. It wasn't until I built SafePrep and started connecting instructors and proctors with students that I realized something — proctors and instructors are vastly underserved. To my knowledge there is nothing out there that supports you in any meaningful way. No community. No resource. No one asking what you need.

That is what my intent is here. To support you. To be a resource. To answer questions. To provide content that actually matters. And to listen.

Your journey is our journey. Your success is our fuel.

You are not in this alone.

— Gerry Miller, Novern Management
FoodSafetyMadeEasy.com

Reflection — Key Takeaways

Everything in this guide distilled to the essentials. Pin this page up. Come back to it.

1. This is a people business. Not a certification business. How you treat people is your product.
 2. Actually caring and pretending to care are both visible. Make sure you actually care.
 3. Your first client will be awkward. Do it anyway. You learn by doing.
 4. Nobody rings your doorbell. You have to find them. Cold calling is how you start.
 5. For every ten calls, maybe one lead. That lead may become five referrals. That's the pyramid.
 6. The clients nobody talks about — hospitals, correctional, schools, assisted living, corporate cafeterias — are your best clients.
 7. Ask the question everywhere you go: "Do you have anyone who needs to get their ServSafe certification?"
 8. Don't undercut. Price to your market. Cheap signals untrustworthy.
 9. Bundle the exam voucher into your package. Perceived value matters.
 10. Time is your most expensive resource. Unprepared students cost you money. Get them ready before class.
 11. Every client you certify today is a renewal client in five years. Build the database now.
 12. Get a website. Create a Google Business Profile. Set up a Facebook page. Do it once. Let it work.
 13. A cold call goes one of two ways. The ones that say yes are ready to pay. Make it easy for them.
 14. The proctors who quit do so in the first 90 days. Stick past that point. The referrals come.
 15. Fifty dollars for one hour of proctoring is all profit. Scale that and you have a business.
 16. You are a walking Yelp review. Did you earn five stars?
 17. The renewal pipeline compounds silently. Every client today is future revenue.
 18. Word of mouth is your best marketing. You don't buy it. You earn it.
 19. SafePrep exists because unprepared students fail. Use it. Recommend it.
 20. You are not in this alone. FoodSafetyMadeEasy.com is here.
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